

THE EMPLOYMENT ASSUMPTION

Who Are the Workshops Really For?

THE CENTRAL QUESTION

*If AISH eligibility requires a permanent inability to earn a livelihood --
and 83.9% of recipients have zero employment income --
who, exactly, are the ADAP workshops designed for?*

This document examines the foundational premise of the Alberta Disability Assistance Program -- and finds it does not survive scrutiny.

83.9%

zero employment income

79,290

being sent to workshops

\$0

employment income for most

WHAT THIS DOCUMENT COVERS

- What ADAP actually requires disabled Albertans to do
- Who is on AISH and what their work history actually shows
- The internal contradiction in the government's own eligibility criteria
- Who is already working -- and what happened to them
- What the research says about disability and employment
- The real cost: human, financial, and constitutional
- What you can do with this information

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown

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PART ONE -- WHAT ADAP ACTUALLY REQUIRES DISABLED ALBERTANS TO DO

When the Government of Alberta describes ADAP, it uses words like empowerment, opportunity, and personalized support. Let us be specific about what the program actually requires.

The ADAP Employment Requirements -- In Plain Language

Personalized Action Plans:

Every ADAP recipient must participate in developing a personalized action plan. This plan is not optional. It is a condition of receiving benefits. The plan is focused on employment goals, skills development, and pathways to work.

Career Planning and Assessment:

Recipients will be required to undergo career planning sessions and employment assessments to identify their employment potential and barriers. This process is administered by government-contracted service providers.

Simulated Worksites:

The ADAP framework includes simulated worksite placements -- structured environments designed to mimic workplace conditions. Recipients are expected to participate in these placements as part of their action plan.

Supported Employment Placements:

Recipients may be placed in supported employment positions -- real or simulated jobs with varying levels of support. Participation is tied to benefit eligibility.

Ongoing Compliance and Reporting:

Recipients must demonstrate ongoing compliance with their action plan. Failure to participate may affect benefit eligibility. The review and enforcement mechanism is administered internally -- there is no independent appeal of these decisions following the elimination of the Citizens Appeal Panel under Bill 12, December 2025.

PAUSE HERE.

Read that list again. These are the requirements being imposed on people whose eligibility for AISH was premised on a formal government finding that they are permanently and substantially limited in their ability to earn a livelihood. The government assessed them as unable to work. Now it is requiring them to attend workshops about how to work. These two things cannot both be true.

PART TWO -- WHO IS ACTUALLY ON AISH

The employment assumption behind ADAP is built on a particular image of who is on AISH. That image does not match the data. Here is who is actually on AISH.

83.9%

of AISH recipients report zero employment income

Government of Alberta Open Data, September 2025

This is not a statistic about laziness or lack of effort. This is a statistic about permanent disability. AISH eligibility requires a formal finding -- by a physician, assessed by the government -- that the applicant is permanently and substantially limited in their ability to earn a livelihood. These are people who have already been through the assessment process. The government already looked at them and said: this person cannot work. And 83.9% of them are not working.

Who They Are -- In Their Own Words

There are people on AISH who have master's degrees. People who had solid careers before becoming unexpectedly disabled. And now she wants to push them into workshops to help them find employment? Does she genuinely believe that someone with a master's degree -- which is more than she has -- would choose to live in poverty if they were able to work?

-- AISH recipient, April 2026

This comment, shared publicly in an AISH community group, received 62 likes and 43 comments within 24 hours. It resonated because it named something that data alone cannot capture: the profound insult of being told you need a workshop by a government that already determined you cannot work.

The Credential Reality

AISH recipients are not a monolith. They include people who:

- Had professional careers -- engineers, teachers, nurses, tradespeople, accountants -- before an injury, illness, or degenerative condition ended their ability to work
- Hold advanced degrees -- bachelors, masters, and doctorates -- and became disabled after completing their education
- Worked for 10, 20, or 30 years before their disability progressed to the point of preventing employment
- Were born with disabilities that prevented them from ever entering the workforce -- not for lack of trying, but because the barriers were insurmountable
- Have tried return-to-work programs before -- some of them multiple times -- and were medically unable to sustain employment
- Are currently managing complex medication regimens, specialist appointments, and unpredictable symptom cycles that make any employment commitment impossible to maintain

The assumption that these people need the government to show them how to find work is not a policy. It is a stereotype. And it is not supported by a single piece of evidence the Government of Alberta has produced.

PART THREE -- THE INTERNAL CONTRADICTION

The Government of Alberta has created a policy framework that contains a fundamental internal contradiction. It cannot be resolved by better communication or a clearer rollout. It is a logical impossibility at the heart of the program.

What AISH Eligibility Actually Requires

THE AISH ELIGIBILITY STANDARD:

To qualify for AISH, an applicant must have a permanent disability that substantially limits their ability to earn a livelihood. The disability must be documented by a physician and assessed by the Government of Alberta. The finding is not that the person is temporarily limited, or limited under current conditions, or limited without support. The finding is that the limitation is PERMANENT.

What ADAP Assumes

THE ADAP EMPLOYMENT PREMISE:

ADAP is built on the premise that recipients have some capacity for employment -- that with the right supports, action plans, career assessments, and workplace simulations, they can move toward financial self-sufficiency through work. This is not stated as a hope. It is built into the structure of the program as a requirement.

The Contradiction -- Side by Side

AISH SAYS:

This person has a permanent disability that substantially limits their ability to earn a livelihood. The limitation is not expected to improve. This person cannot work.

ADAP SAYS:

This person has some capacity for employment. With appropriate supports and a personalized action plan, they can work toward financial self-sufficiency.

Both of these statements apply to the same 79,290 people. They cannot both be true. Either the AISH assessment was wrong -- in which case the government issued years of benefits to people it incorrectly assessed -- or the ADAP employment premise is wrong. There is no third option.

The Government of Alberta has not explained this contradiction. It has not commissioned a new population-level assessment. It has not published the criteria it will use to determine who has employment capacity. It has simply assumed -- without evidence -- that the people it previously assessed as permanently unable to work are now available for employment programming.

The Government's Own Data Refutes Its Own Premise

If ADAP's employment premise were correct -- if these 79,290 people genuinely had latent employment capacity waiting to be unlocked -- we would expect to see some evidence of it in the existing data. We do not.

- 83.9% of AISH recipients report zero employment income (GoA Open Data, September 2025). Under the current earned income exemption of \$1,072 per month, recipients are allowed to work without penalty. Most are not working -- not because they are prohibited, but because they cannot.
- AISH has always permitted employment. The program is not and has never been a prohibition on working. Recipients who can work part-time or occasionally already do. The 83.9% who report zero income have not chosen not to work. They are unable to.
- The assessment process for AISH is not casual. It requires physician documentation and government review. A finding of permanent inability to earn a livelihood is not made lightly and is not expected to reverse.

- No new population-level assessment has been conducted. The government is not transitioning people to ADAP based on new evidence that their employment capacity has changed. It is transitioning them based on a policy decision, not a medical one.

PART FOUR -- WHO IS ALREADY WORKING, AND WHAT HAPPENED TO THEM

16.1 percent of AISH recipients do report some employment income. These are the people the government points to as evidence that employment is possible. They deserve to be looked at more carefully -- because what is happening to them under ADAP is not a reward for working. It is a punishment.

16.1%

of AISH recipients report some employment income

Government of Alberta Open Data, September 2025

What the Earned Income Exemption Change Does to Working Recipients

Under AISH, recipients can earn up to \$1,072 per month before their benefits are reduced. This threshold was designed to allow people with disabilities to supplement their income through whatever work they are able to do -- whether that is a few hours a week, occasional contract work, or part-time employment -- without being penalized.

Effective July 1, 2026, the earned income exemption drops to \$350 per month under ADAP. Every dollar earned above \$350 is clawed back from benefits dollar for dollar.

WHAT THIS MEANS IN PRACTICE:

A recipient who currently works part-time earning \$800 per month -- within the AISH exemption and without penalty -- will face a clawback of \$450 per month under ADAP. Their incentive to work has not been increased. It has been eliminated. The people who are currently working, within the constraints of their disability, are being financially penalized for doing so.

The Work Disincentive Built Into ADAP

An employment program that financially punishes recipients for working is not an employment program. It is an income reduction with an employment label attached. The 16.1% who are already working -- already demonstrating exactly the employment capacity ADAP claims to be developing -- are worse off under ADAP than they were under AISH. If the goal were genuinely to support employment, the earned income exemption would have been maintained or increased, not cut by 67 percent.

The Administrative Cost Reality

The Government of Alberta's own Budget 2026 documents reveal the following:

- AISH administrative cost: \$46.8 million
- ADAP administrative cost: \$88.4 million
- Net increase in administrative cost: \$41.6 million per year

The government is spending \$41.6 million more per year to administer a program that pays recipients \$200 less per month, cuts the employment exemption by \$722 per month, removes independent appeal rights, and sends people with permanent disabilities to employment workshops. The workshops are not free. The service providers running them are being paid. That money is coming from somewhere. It is not coming from improved outcomes for disabled Albertans.

PART FIVE -- WHAT THE RESEARCH ACTUALLY SAYS ABOUT DISABILITY AND EMPLOYMENT

The Government of Alberta's employment assumption is not new. Governments have tried versions of it before. The research on what actually happens when disability programs impose employment requirements is consistent and clear.

Employment requirements do not increase employment rates for people with severe disabilities.

Multiple peer-reviewed studies across Canada, the United Kingdom, and Australia have found that work-first activation programs do not produce sustained employment outcomes for people with serious, permanent, or fluctuating disabilities. The barriers are not attitudinal or motivational. They are structural: employer discrimination, inaccessible workplaces, unpredictable symptoms, and healthcare systems that cannot sustain working disabled people.

They do increase poverty, stress, and health deterioration.

Research consistently shows that imposing employment participation requirements on people with disabilities who cannot sustain work leads to increased financial stress, worsening of mental and physical health symptoms, and higher rates of benefit loss without corresponding employment gains. The net effect is more poverty, not less.

Work-first programs perform worst for the most disabled.

The people least likely to benefit from employment programming are those with the most severe, complex, or unpredictable disabilities -- precisely the population that AISH was designed to serve. Applying an employment-focused framework to this population does not unlock latent capacity. It adds administrative burden and financial penalty to people already managing extraordinary circumstances.

Supported employment works -- but not like this.

There is evidence that voluntary, well-resourced supported employment programs can help some people with disabilities access part-time or flexible work. But those programs work because they are voluntary, individually tailored, and designed around the person's actual capacity. They do not cut income while imposing participation requirements. ADAP is not a supported employment program. It is a compliance program.

The disability community has been here before.

The UK's Work Capability Assessment, Australia's Disability Employment Services reforms, and Ontario's Ontario Works disability stream have all been studied. The findings are remarkably consistent: mandatory employment programming for severely disabled people increases administrative costs, produces minimal employment outcomes, and causes measurable harm to health and wellbeing. Alberta is not innovating. It is repeating documented failures.

PART SIX -- THE REAL COST: HUMAN, FINANCIAL, AND CONSTITUTIONAL

The Human Cost

Behind the statistics are people. Specific, individual people whose lives are shaped by the policy decisions being made in Edmonton. Consider who is actually being sent to these workshops:

- The former nurse with MS who had to stop working when her symptoms became unpredictable and dangerous -- now required to develop an action plan for returning to a workplace she medically cannot safely enter
- The engineer with a traumatic brain injury who spent three years relearning to speak and manage basic daily tasks -- now assessed as having employment potential by a program contractor who has never met him
- The person with severe bipolar disorder who has been hospitalized four times in the past two years -- now required to attend career planning sessions as a condition of receiving the \$1,740 per month that is the only thing standing between her and homelessness
- The parent with fibromyalgia who manages her condition around her children's school schedule and medical appointments -- now facing a \$722 cut to her earned income exemption that will take away any financial incentive to work the few hours she currently can
- The 28-year-old with a congenital disability who has never been able to work and has tried every supported employment program available -- now being sent back through a process that has already failed him, by a government that has already assessed him as permanently unable to earn a livelihood

The Financial Cost -- To Alberta

The financial argument for ADAP has never been coherently made. The program costs \$41.6 million more to administer than AISH. The employment outcomes -- the supposed rationale for the higher cost -- are not projected in any document the government has released. There is no modelling showing how many AISH recipients will become employed under ADAP, what those employment rates will be, or what the net fiscal impact will be after accounting for the cost of employment programming, service providers, assessments, appeals (such as they exist), and the inevitable health deterioration that will produce increased healthcare costs downstream.

The Constitutional Cost -- To All of Us

When a government imposes a policy that contradicts its own assessment framework, removes the right of appeal, and requires participation in employment programming as a condition of survival income for people it has formally assessed as unable to work -- it is not just making a bad policy decision. It is testing the limits of constitutional tolerance.

Section 7 of the Charter protects security of the person. Section 15 prohibits discrimination based on disability. Section 6 protects the right to pursue a livelihood in any province. All three are engaged by the employment assumption at the heart of ADAP. When a government creates a policy that is logically inconsistent with its own eligibility criteria, the courts are the last line of defense. This document is part of building the record that courts will need.

PART SEVEN -- WHAT YOU CAN DO WITH THIS DOCUMENT

This document is evidence. Use it.

Send it to your MLA and MP.

Every elected representative who receives this document has been formally put on notice that the employment assumption behind ADAP is unsupported by evidence, internally contradictory, and potentially unconstitutional. Keep a record of who you sent it to and when. Request a written response. Their silence is also a record.

Send it to Minister Jason Nixon.

rimbey.rockymountainhouse.sundre@assembly.ab.ca -- The Minister responsible for ADAP should be required to answer the central question of this document: if AISH eligibility requires permanent inability to earn a livelihood, what is the evidence base for the claim that these same people have employment capacity?

Send it to Premier Smith.

premier@gov.ab.ca -- The Premier has publicly defended the ADAP transition as an empowerment initiative. She should be asked to reconcile that framing with the internal contradiction documented here.

Send it to federal representatives.

HUMA@parl.gc.ca and your federal MP. The federal government sent \$200 per month to disabled Albertans through the Canada Disability Benefit. Alberta is clawing it back and redirecting it to fund an employment program premised on a contradiction. Federal legislators should know this.

Share it in every disability community you are part of.

The more people who understand the internal contradiction at the heart of ADAP, the harder it becomes for the government to sustain the framing of this as empowerment. This document is free. Share it without restriction.

Add your story.

The most powerful version of this argument is not statistical. It is personal. If you have tried to work. If you have been through return-to-work programming. If you have a professional background that preceded your disability. If you have already been assessed as permanently unable to work -- your story is the evidence that the employment assumption has always been wrong. Share it. Submit it. Put it on the record.

THE BOTTOM LINE:

The employment assumption behind ADAP is not a policy grounded in evidence. It is a stereotype applied at scale to 79,290 people the government already assessed as permanently unable to work -- at greater cost, with fewer rights, and with no published evidence that it will produce the outcomes it claims to pursue. The question this document asks is simple: who are the workshops really for? The answer the data provides is equally simple: not for the people being sent to them.

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